

Language decorum: School education should not be the site of a cultural battle

Original Editorial

The Supreme Court of India has issued notices to the Union Government, the CBSE, and the NCERT, directing them to file a **comprehensive** report on their logistical preparedness to implement a three-language formula in all CBSE schools for Class 9 students from July 1, 2026. On May 27, while hearing petitioners challenging the CBSE move, the Court declined to grant an immediate stay on the policy but acknowledged that concerns over "**hardship** and inconvenience" warranted review. The Court will hear arguments on July 15 and 16. The casual manner in which the government is using the CBSE to enforce its **contentious** language policy once again shows complete **disregard** for students, teachers, and parents. On May 15, the CBSE had issued a circular **mandating** the study of three languages for Class 9 students from July 1, citing **alignment** with the NEP 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education 2023. At least two of the three must be native Indian languages. Foreign languages such as French or German could only be taken as a third language if the first two were Indian, or alternatively as an optional fourth subject. In a **meagre** effort to **camouflage** the hardship unleashed on the students, the CBSE exempted the third language from the Class 10 Board examination, which would instead be assessed through school-based internal evaluations, though the marks would still appear on the final certificate.

Barely weeks earlier, the CBSE had stated that the third-language requirement would be **deferred** until the 2029-30 academic year. The **abrupt turnaround** can only be explained as a political decision. The move is being challenged in the Court on multiple grounds, including constitutional ones. The petitioners argue that language is a matter of personal choice and cannot be imposed by the state. It is also being pointed out that the NEP 2020, in whose name the **mandate** is being enforced, promises flexibility and guarantees that

no language shall be imposed on any student or State. The petitioners also argue that the CBSE, as an executive body, lacks the authority to impose such a **sweeping** educational mandate without backing from parliamentary legislation, regardless of what the NEP says, being an executive policy intent and not a **statute**. Parents and teachers are alarmed about the added pressure on students just before their Board examinations. School administrators have flagged a shortage of trained language teachers and the unavailability of appropriate textbooks. Turning school education into a cultural battleground is not helping India's ambition to become a global **reservoir** of advanced human resources. The Centre should course-correct before the Court takes up the case again.

Article Summary

The editorial criticizes the abrupt enforcement of the three-language formula by the CBSE for Class 9 students, a move currently under review by the Supreme Court. While the policy mandates the study of at least two native Indian languages—aligning with the NEP 2020—critics view it as a politically motivated and contentious decision that disregards the logistical realities of schools, such as textbook and teacher shortages. Petitioners have challenged the mandate, arguing that language is a personal choice, the NEP actually guarantees flexibility, and the CBSE lacks the statutory authority to impose such sweeping changes. The editorial concludes by urging the central government to reconsider its stance, emphasizing that turning education into a cultural battleground severely undermines India's goal of developing advanced human resources.

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Editorial Anatomy

1. The Trigger: CBSE's Three-Language Mandate



2. The Friction: Court Challenges & Logistical Flaws



3. The Argument: Lack of Statutory Authority & NEP Flexibility



4. The Verdict: Course-Correction Required for Educational Growth

Vocabulary Builder: 15 Difficult & Important Words

Word (PoS)	Meaning (Hindi / English)	Synonyms (5)	Antonyms (5)
comprehensive (Adjective)	व्यापक Complete; including all or nearly all elements or aspects of something.	exhaustive, thorough, extensive, complete, all-inclusive	partial, limited, incomplete, restricted, superficial
hardship (Noun)	कठिनाई Severe suffering or privation.	privation, adversity, suffering, trouble, difficulty	comfort, ease, prosperity, relief, benefit

Word (PoS)	Meaning (Hindi / English)	Synonyms (5)	Antonyms (5)
contentious (Adjective)	विवादग्रस्त Causing or likely to cause an argument; controversial.	controversial, debatable, disputable, litigious, argumentative	uncontroversial, agreeable, peaceful, harmonious, undisputed
disregard (Noun)	उपेक्षा The action or state of paying no attention to something.	neglect, indifference, inattention, disrespect, apathy	attention, respect, regard, consideration, heed
mandating (Verb)	अनिवार्य करना Require (something) to be done; dictate.	requiring, dictating, ordering, commanding, decreeing	suggesting, requesting, asking, pleading, appealing
alignment (Noun)	संरेखण / तालमेल Arrangement in correct relative positions or a state of agreement.	integration, coordination, synchronization, arrangement, harmony	misalignment, disorder, divergence, nonconformity, disagreement
meagre (Adjective)	अल्प Lacking in quantity or quality.	inadequate, scanty, insufficient, sparse, paltry	abundant, plentiful, ample, generous, substantial
camouflage (Verb)	छिपाना Hide or disguise the presence of (a person, animal, or object).	disguise, conceal, mask, hide, cloak	reveal, expose, uncover, show, highlight
deferred (Verb)	स्थगित Put off (an action or event) to a later time; postpone.	postponed, delayed, suspended, adjourned, prolonged	expedited, advanced, hastened, accelerated, hurried
abrupt (Adjective)	अचानक Sudden and unexpected.	sudden, unexpected, rapid, unforeseen, hasty	gradual, slow, expected, anticipated, leisurely

Word (PoS)	Meaning (Hindi / English)	Synonyms (5)	Antonyms (5)
turnabout (Noun)	परिवर्तन A sudden and complete change or reversal of policy or opinion.	reversal, shift, transformation, alteration, U-turn	continuation, persistence, stagnation, stability, retention
mandate (Noun)	जनादेश / आदेश An official order or commission to do something.	instruction, directive, decree, command, order	recommendation, suggestion, request, petition, appeal
sweeping (Adjective)	व्यापक Wide in range or effect.	extensive, broad, far-reaching, comprehensive, overarching	limited, narrow, restricted, confined, localized
statute (Noun)	क़ानून A written law passed by a legislative body.	law, act, decree, edict, rule	custom, tradition, convention, informality, unwritten rule
reservoir (Noun)	भंडार A large supply or source of something.	pool, store, reserve, fund, stock	depletion, lack, emptiness, void, drain

Additional Important Words & Parts of Speech

- **Logistical** — Adjective (Relating to the organization and implementation of a complex operation).
- **Inconvenience** — Noun (Trouble or difficulty caused to one's personal requirements or comfort).
- **Alternatively** — Adverb (As another option or possibility).
- **Constitutional** — Adjective (Relating to an established set of principles governing a state).
- **Administrators** — Noun (People responsible for carrying out the administration of a business or organization).

Idioms and Phrases

1. Take up

Meaning: To consider, begin dealing with, or accept (an issue or challenge).

Example: The committee decided to take up the environmental issues during the next session.

2. Course-correct

Meaning: To adjust one's path, policy, or strategy to avoid making a mistake or to improve outcomes.

Example: Facing declining sales, the company had to quickly course-correct its marketing strategy.

3. On multiple grounds

Meaning: For several different reasons or justifications.

Example: The controversial law was challenged in the Supreme Court on multiple grounds by civil rights activists.

Practice Questions: Fill in the Blanks

1. The committee submitted a/an _____ report detailing every possible aspect and risk of the upcoming construction project.

- A) superficial
- B) partial
- C) exhaustive
- D) brief
- E) restricted

2. The sudden _____ in the central bank's financial policy surprised all the investors who had prepared for a rate cut.

- A) continuation
- B) reversal
- C) stagnation
- D) persistence
- E) extension

3. Implementing such a _____ educational reform across the country will require substantial parliamentary and financial backing.

- A) localized
- B) minor
- C) far-reaching
- D) trivial
- E) confined

4. Many families in the drought-affected region are facing severe _____ due to unprecedented water scarcity this summer.

- A) comfort
- B) luxury
- C) prosperity
- D) adversity
- E) ease

5. The government's decision to enforce a new strict dress code proved to be highly _____ among the student body.

- A) agreeable
- B) undisputed
- C) controversial
- D) peaceful
- E) harmonious

Practice Questions: Error Detection

6. (A) The Supreme Court of India / (B) has issued notices to the Union Government, / (C) directing them to filed a / (D) comprehensive report on their logistical preparedness. / (E) No Error.

7. (A) The casual manner in which / (B) the government is using the CBSE / (C) to enforce its contentious language policy / (D) once again show complete disregard. / (E) No Error.

8. (A) At least two of / (B) the three language / (C) must be native / (D) Indian languages. / (E) No Error.

9. (A) The petitioners argue that / (B) language is a matter / (C) of personal choice and cannot / (D) be imposed by the state. / (E) No Error.

10. (A) School administrators have flagged / (B) a shortages of trained / (C) language teachers and the unavailability / (D) of appropriate textbooks. / (E) No Error.

Practice Questions: Reading Comprehension

Paragraph 1: The Supreme Court of India has issued notices to the Union Government and CBSE, directing them to file a comprehensive report on their logistical preparedness to implement a three-language formula in all CBSE schools for Class 9 students from July 1, 2026. The Court declined to grant an immediate stay but acknowledged that concerns over "hardship and inconvenience" warranted review. The CBSE circular mandates the study of three languages, citing alignment with the NEP 2020. At least two of the three must be native Indian languages, while foreign languages like French or German can only be taken as a third language if the first two were Indian, or as an optional fourth subject.

Paragraph 2: Barely weeks earlier, the CBSE had stated that the third-language requirement would be deferred until 2029-30. This abrupt turnabout is being challenged in Court. Petitioners argue that language is a matter of personal choice and that the NEP 2020 actually promises flexibility and guarantees that no language shall be imposed. They further argue that CBSE lacks the authority to impose a sweeping educational mandate without parliamentary legislation. School administrators have also flagged shortages of trained teachers and textbooks. Turning education into a cultural battleground is harming India's ambition to become a global reservoir of advanced human resources.

11. What is the primary directive given by the Supreme Court to the Union Government and CBSE?

- A) To immediately cancel the implementation of the three-language formula.
- B) To file a report on logistical preparedness for the three-language formula.
- C) To make foreign languages mandatory for Class 9 students universally.
- D) To exempt all Class 10 students from their upcoming board examinations.
- E) To transfer all educational authority directly from the CBSE to NCERT.

12. According to the CBSE circular, what is the condition for taking a foreign language like French or German?

- A) It must permanently replace one of the native Indian languages.
- B) It can only be taken if the first two languages are Indian, or as a fourth subject.
- C) It is strictly prohibited under the new National Curriculum Framework guidelines.
- D) It must be taught by foreign teachers exclusively imported for this program.
- E) It is unconditionally mandatory for all students regardless of their native tongue.

13. Why is the CBSE's recent decision regarding the third-language requirement described as an "abrupt turnabout"?

- A) Because it was introduced by a completely different educational board previously.
- B) Because they had just stated weeks earlier that it would be deferred until 2029-30.
- C) Because the students themselves overwhelmingly voted to implement it immediately.
- D) Because it contradicts a direct, written order given by the Supreme Court of India.
- E) Because it focuses solely on foreign languages instead of prioritizing Indian ones.

14. On what grounds do the petitioners argue that the CBSE lacks the authority to impose this mandate?

- A) Because CBSE is an unrecognised body under the National Education Policy 2020.
- B) Because it is an executive body acting without backing from parliamentary legislation.
- C) Because it does not have enough trained language teachers to enforce the rules.
- D) Because education is strictly a state subject and the Centre cannot intervene at all.
- E) Because the language policy aggressively violates international educational standards.

15. What overarching concern does the editorial express regarding the state of school education?

- A) That India is failing to attract international students to its premier educational institutions.
- B) That there are far too many subjects being forcibly taught in the modern curriculum.
- C) That turning education into a cultural battleground harms India's human resources ambition.
- D) That the Supreme Court is drastically overstepping its boundaries in educational matters.
- E) That native Indian languages are entirely losing their relevance on the global stage.



Answers & Explanations

Fill in the Blanks Answers

1. Answer: C) exhaustive

Explanation: The original word in the editorial is "comprehensive". "Exhaustive" is the most appropriate synonym, meaning fully comprehensive and detailed.

2. Answer: B) reversal

Explanation: The original word is "turnabout". "Reversal" correctly captures the meaning of a sudden change in policy or direction.

3. Answer: C) far-reaching

Explanation: The original text uses "sweeping". "Far-reaching" is a direct synonym that means having a wide range or extensive effect.

4. Answer: D) adversity

Explanation: The editorial uses "hardship". "Adversity" signifies severe difficulties or suffering, making it the perfect fit.

5. Answer: C) controversial

Explanation: The original sentence uses "contentious", meaning causing argument. "Controversial" effectively conveys this same idea.

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Error Detection Answers

6. Answer: (C)

Explanation: The error is in part (C). With the infinitive marker 'to', the base form of the verb should be used. It should be "to file", not "to filed".

7. Answer: (D)

Explanation: The error lies in part (D). The subject of the sentence is "The casual manner", which is singular. Therefore, the verb must be singular. It should be "shows", not "show".

8. Answer: (B)

Explanation: The error is in part (B). Since "two of the three" refers to multiple items, the noun must be plural. It should be "languages", not "language".

9. Answer: (E)

Explanation: There is no grammatical or structural error in this sentence. The sentence is completely correct.

10. Answer: (B)

Explanation: The error is in part (B). The article "a" is singular, so it should be followed by a singular noun. It should be "a shortage", not "a shortages".

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Reading Comprehension Answers

11. Answer: B) To file a report on logistical preparedness for the three-language formula.

Explanation: Paragraph 1 explicitly states that the Supreme Court directed them "to file a comprehensive report on their logistical preparedness to implement a three-language formula."

12. Answer: B) It can only be taken if the first two languages are Indian, or as a fourth subject.

Explanation: Paragraph 1 clearly notes that foreign languages "could only be taken as a third language if the first two were Indian, or alternatively as an optional fourth subject."

13. Answer: B) Because they had just stated weeks earlier that it would be deferred until 2029-30.

Explanation: Paragraph 2 mentions, "Barely weeks earlier, the CBSE had stated that the third-language requirement would be deferred until the 2029-30 academic year," making the current move an abrupt turnabout.

14. Answer: B) Because it is an executive body acting without backing from parliamentary legislation.

Explanation: The passage states petitioners argue that the CBSE, "as an executive body, lacks the authority to impose such a sweeping educational mandate without backing from parliamentary legislation."

15. Answer: C) That turning education into a cultural battleground harms India's human resources ambition.

Explanation: The final sentences of the passage warn that "Turning school education into a cultural battleground is not helping India's ambition to become a global reservoir of advanced human resources."

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"Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world." – Nelson Mandela

"Gratitude is the inward feeling of kindness received. Thankfulness is the natural impulse to express that feeling. Keep learning, keep growing!"

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